FREE PLANNING GUIDE

Sea to Sky
Trip Planner 2026-27

Vancouver • Squamish • Whistler • Pemberton

Where to eat, stay, hike, and explore, with typical costs, trail ratings, and seasonal tips.

bestseatosky.com

2026-27 Edition • Free Download

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1. At a Glance

Total Distance	Vancouver to Pemberton: about 150 km (2.5 hrs non-stop)
Main Towns	Squamish (pop. about 25,000) • Whistler (pop. about 13,000) • Pemberton (pop. about 3,000)
Good For	Hiking, skiing, climbing, craft beer, waterfalls, scenic drives
Peak Season	June to September (summer) and December to March (ski)
Getting There	Drive from Vancouver on Highway 99, the Sea to Sky Highway
Fuel	Fill up in Squamish or Whistler; stations get sparse heading north
Cell Service	Good in towns, spotty on trails and between Whistler and Pemberton
Parking	Free at most trailheads; paid parking at Sea to Sky Gondola

2. Budget Breakdown

Typical costs in the Sea to Sky corridor, in CAD. Prices change by season, so check before you book.

Accommodation (per night)

	Squamish	Whistler	Pemberton
Budget (hostel/camping)	$25-45	$30-60	$20-40
Mid-range (hotel/Airbnb)	$150-250	$250-450	$120-200
Luxury (resort/chalet)	$250-400	$450-900+	$200-350

Food & Drink

Item	Typical Cost
Coffee	$4-6
Casual lunch	$15-22
Dinner for two (mid-range)	$80-140
Dinner for two (upscale, Whistler)	$150-250+
Pint of craft beer	$7-9
Flight of beer (4 tasters)	$12-16
Groceries for a day (self-catering)	$40-60

Activities & Attractions

Activity	Cost
Sea to Sky Gondola (adult)	Check current rates
Whistler Blackcomb lift tickets and bike park passes	Varies by date; check current rates
Scandinave Spa Whistler entry	Check current rates
Guided rock climbing (half day)	$150-200 pp
Kayak rental (2 hours)	$40-60
Mountain bike rental (full day)	$80-130
Joffre Lakes Park day-use pass	Check bcparks.ca for current rules
Most hiking trails	Free
Shannon Falls / Brandywine Falls	Free day use

Budget Tip: Squamish is usually cheaper than Whistler for accommodation and dining. Base yourself in Squamish and day-trip to Whistler to save money.

Sample Daily Budgets

Style	Per Person/Day	Includes
Backpacker	$60-100	Camping, self-catering, free hikes, one beer
Comfortable	$150-250	Mid-range hotel, lunch + dinner out, one activity
Luxury	$400-700	Resort stay, fine dining, gondola + spa

3. Seasonal Guide

Summer (June to September)

Peak season. All trails accessible, waterfalls flowing, patios open, days are long (sunset after 9pm in July).

What's On	Details
Hiking	All trails open including alpine. Check bcparks.ca for Joffre Lakes day-use pass rules.
Mountain biking	Whistler Bike Park open. Squamish trails in prime condition.
Water sports	Kayaking, paddleboarding, kiteboarding on the Squamish Spit.
Climbing	Peak season. Long days mean more time on the wall.
Weather	20-30°C in valleys. 10-20°C on summits. Rain is rare but pack layers.
Crowds	Busy weekends. Book accommodation 2-4 weeks ahead. Hike early.

Summer Tip: The Squamish Spit gets thermal winds most afternoons from May to September. Even if you don't kiteboard, watching from the estuary at sunset is worth it.

Winter (December to March)

Ski season transforms the corridor. Whistler Blackcomb is the main draw, plus eagle watching, snowshoeing, and spas.

What's On	Details
Skiing/Snowboarding	Whistler Blackcomb: 8,000+ acres, 200+ runs. Buy tickets online.
Cross-country	Lost Lake trails (Whistler). Callaghan Country (backcountry).
Snowshoeing	Whistler Olympic Park and Elfin Lakes area.
Eagle watching	Brackendale (Dec-Feb). Bald eagles gather along the Squamish River.
Spas	Scandinave Spa Whistler. Hot pools surrounded by snow-covered trees.
Weather	-5 to 5°C in valleys. -15 to -5°C on mountains. Heavy snow above 800m.
Crowds	Christmas and spring break are peak. Midweek is noticeably quieter.

Winter Tip: Start at Creekside Gondola instead of Whistler Village for often shorter lines on the same mountain. Midweek skiing is a completely different experience.

Shoulder Seasons

Spring (April-May): Waterfalls at peak flow. Lower trails open, alpine still snowy. Fewer crowds, lower prices.

Fall (October-November): Autumn colours and mushroom foraging. A quiet time to visit.

4. Highway Stops: Vancouver to Pemberton

Worthwhile stops along the Sea to Sky Highway, in order from south to north.

Porteau Cove Provincial Park

25 min from Horseshoe Bay

Waterfront park with Howe Sound views. Popular for scuba diving. Rocky beach, mountain backdrop, campground.

Cost: Free day use (camping fees apply)

Britannia Mine Museum

Britannia Beach

Underground train tour, gold panning, mining history. Good for kids. Budget 90 minutes.

Cost: Paid admission; check current rates

Shannon Falls Provincial Park

10 min south of Squamish

335 m waterfall, a short walk from parking. Most impressive in spring.

Cost: Free

Sea to Sky Gondola

Next to Shannon Falls

Gondola ride to an 885 m summit. Suspension bridge, hiking trails, restaurant.

Cost: Paid; check current rates

Tantalus Lookout

Highway pullout north of Squamish

Head-on view of the Tantalus Range and its glaciers.

Cost: Free

Brandywine Falls Provincial Park

South of Whistler

70 m waterfall into a volcanic canyon. Easy 10-minute walk. Continue to Swim Lake in summer.

Cost: Free

Nairn Falls Provincial Park

South of Pemberton

1.5 km trail through old-growth forest to a powerful cascade. Usually less crowded than Shannon Falls.

Cost: Free day use (camping fees apply)

Full road trip guide: bestseatosky.com/blog/sea-to-sky-highway-road-trip-itinerary

5. Squamish

Climbing, mountain biking, hiking, and a busy craft beer scene, all at the head of Howe Sound.

Where to Eat

Restaurant	Known For
Howe Sound Inn & Brewing	Brewpub, house-brewed beer, inn
The Locavore Bar & Grill	Farm-to-table, seasonal menu
Fergie's Café	Brunch cafe in Brackendale
Mags99 Fried Chicken and Mexican Cantina	Fried chicken, Mexican cantina
Backcountry Brewing	Brewery taproom, wood-fired pizza
A-FRAME Brewing Co	Craft brewery taproom
The Crabapple Café	Breakfast, brunch, lunch in Brackendale

Full guide: bestseatosky.com/guide/best-restaurants-squamish

Where to Stay

Option	Type
Sandman Hotel & Suites Squamish	Hotel, Discovery Way
Executive Suites Hotel & Resort, Squamish	Resort hotel
Sunwolf Riverside Resort	Riverside cabins, Brackendale
Alice Lake Campgrounds	Provincial park campground
Squamish Adventure Inn & Hostel	Hostel and inn, budget

Full guide: bestseatosky.com/guide/best-hotels-squamish

Things to Do

Canadian Coastal Sailing: Small-group afternoon and sunset sails on Howe Sound, plus private charters.

More ideas: bestseatosky.com/guide/things-to-do-squamish

6. Squamish Trail Guide

Popular hikes rated by difficulty, distance, and time.

Trail	Difficulty	Distance	Time	Highlights
Shannon Falls	Easy	0.5 km	15 min	335 m waterfall. Paved path.
Estuary Trails	Easy	3-5 km	1-2 hrs	Flat, river views, eagles, sunset spot.
Four Lakes Trail	Easy-Mod	6 km loop	2-3 hrs	Four lakes, swimming in summer.
Chief 1st Peak	Hard	4 km	2-3 hrs	Granite scramble. Howe Sound views.
Chief 2nd Peak	Hard	5 km	4-5 hrs	Big summit, usually less crowded.
Chief 3rd Peak	Hard	7 km	5-7 hrs	Highest of the three (702m). Garibaldi views.
Garibaldi Lake	Moderate	18 km	5-7 hrs	Turquoise alpine lake.
Elfin Lakes	Moderate	22 km	6-8 hrs	Alpine meadows, overnight hut available.
Sea to Summit	Moderate	7.5 km	3-4 hrs	Forest trail to Gondola summit.
Smoke Bluffs	Easy	2-4 km	1-2 hrs	Climbing crag views. Loop trails.
Brandywine Meadows	Hard	10 km	5-6 hrs	Alpine wildflowers in July-Aug.

Trail Tip: Start the Chief before 8 AM on weekends. Second Peak is the local's choice: same views, more space, fewer selfie sticks.

Full guide: bestseatosky.com/guide/best-hikes-squamish

7. Whistler

Two mountains, 8,000+ acres of ski and bike terrain, and a pedestrian village with dining, shopping, and nightlife.

Where to Eat

Restaurant	Known For
Rimrock Café	Seafood restaurant
Araxi Restaurant & Oyster Bar	Pacific Northwest dining, oysters
Purebread Bakery + Coffee	Bakery and coffee, Whistler Village
Sushi Village Japanese Restaurant	Japanese, sushi
El Furniture Warehouse	Burgers, bar, breakfast
Hunter Gather	Gastropub, breakfast, lunch
The Longhorn Saloon	Bar and grill
Whistler Brewing Company Taphouse	Brewery taphouse, pub food

Full guide: bestseatosky.com/guide/best-restaurants-whistler

Where to Stay

Option	Type
Fairmont Chateau Whistler	Resort hotel, ski-in/ski-out
The Westin Resort & Spa, Whistler	Resort and spa, base of Whistler Mountain
Pangea Pod Hotel	Pod hotel, Whistler Village
Nita Lake Lodge	Lakeside lodge, Creekside
HI Whistler	Hostel
The Crystal Lodge, Whistler Hotel	Hotel, Village Green

Full guide: bestseatosky.com/guide/best-hotels-whistler

8. Whistler Trail Guide

Trail	Difficulty	Distance	Time	Highlights
Lost Lake Loop	Easy	5 km	1-2 hrs	Flat loop, swimming, free. Year-round.
Train Wreck Falls	Easy	2 km	30 min	Suspension bridge to graffiti train cars.
Cheakamus River	Easy	3 km	1 hr	Riverside walk, old-growth forest.
Whistler Peak Trail	Moderate	5 km	2-3 hrs	From gondola summit. Alpine views.
Russet Lake	Hard	26 km	8-10 hrs	Musical Bumps to Singing Pass.
Wedgemount Lake	Hard	12 km	5-7 hrs	Steep climb to a glacier lake.
High Note Trail	Moderate	9 km	3-4 hrs	Panoramic alpine views. Gondola access.
Flute Summit	Hard	12 km	5-6 hrs	Above the treeline. Musical Bumps.
Rainbow Falls	Easy	3 km	1 hr	Gentle forest walk to waterfall.
Helm Creek	Hard	22 km	7-9 hrs	Black Tusk views. Backcountry camping.

Trail Tip: High Note Trail gives big views for the effort. Gondola up, walk the ridge with 360° views, ride back down.

Full guide: bestseatosky.com/guide/best-hikes-whistler

9. Pemberton

A farming valley surrounded by peaks, home to Joffre Lakes.

Where to Eat

Restaurant	Known For
Mile One Eating House	Casual eatery
The Pony	Restaurant, comfort food
Blackbird Bakery	Bread, pastries, coffee
Grimm's Gourmet & Deli Ltd & Brooklyn's Pizza	Deli, pizza, coffee

Full guide: bestseatosky.com/guide/best-restaurants-pemberton

Where to Stay

Option	Type
Pemberton Valley Lodge	Lodge
Pemberton Hotel	Historic hotel, Frontier Street
Nairn Falls Campground	Provincial park campground

Full guide: bestseatosky.com/guide/best-hotels-pemberton

10. Pemberton Trail Guide

Trail	Difficulty	Distance	Time	Highlights
Joffre Lakes	Moderate	10 km	3-4 hrs	Three turquoise glacier lakes. Check pass rules.
Nairn Falls	Easy	3 km	1 hr	Powerful cascade, old-growth forest.
One Mile Lake	Easy	1.5 km	30 min	Lakeside loop, swimming, family-friendly.
Mount Currie Trail	Hard	14 km	6-8 hrs	Summit views over the entire valley.
Tenquille Lake	Hard	24 km	8-10 hrs	Remote alpine lake. Backcountry hut.
Mosquito Lake	Moderate	8 km	3-4 hrs	Lake swimming, forest walk.

> **Trail Tip:** Joffre Lakes is very busy in summer. Check day-use pass rules at bcparks.ca before you go and arrive by 8 AM.

Full guide: bestseatosky.com/guide/best-hikes-pemberton

11. Packing Checklist

Summer Essentials

- Hiking boots or sturdy trail shoes
- Layers: mountain weather changes fast
- Light rain jacket
- Sunscreen SPF 50+ and sunglasses
- Reusable water bottle
- Camera or phone with plenty of storage
- Trail snacks and lunch for longer hikes
- Swimsuit for lake swimming
- Insect repellent (June-August)
- Cash or card for parking meters
- Bear spray for remote trails
- Headlamp (just in case)

Winter Essentials

- Warm layers (base layer, fleece, insulated jacket)
- Waterproof outer shell
- Warm toque/beanie and gloves
- Ski goggles
- Hand warmers
- Winter tires or chains (required on Highway 99 in winter; check drivebc.ca for dates)
- Lip balm with SPF
- Thermos for hot drinks
- Ski pass (check online rates in advance)

12. Planning Resources

Our Guides (Free)

Guide	Link
Best Restaurants in Squamish	bestseatosky.com/guide/best-restaurants-squamish
Best Restaurants in Whistler	bestseatosky.com/guide/best-restaurants-whistler
Best Restaurants in Pemberton	bestseatosky.com/guide/best-restaurants-pemberton
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Article	Link
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48 Hours in Squamish	bestseatosky.com/blog/48-hours-in-squamish-weekend-itinerary
Local's Guide to Whistler in Winter	bestseatosky.com/blog/locals-guide-whistler-winter
Squamish vs Whistler: Where to Stay?	bestseatosky.com/blog/squamish-vs-whistler-where-to-stay
Filming Locations (Virgin River +)	bestseatosky.com/blog/movies-tv-shows-filmed-sea-to-sky

AI Trip Planner

Need personalized recommendations? Try our free AI Trip Planner:

bestseatosky.com/chat

Ask it anything: "What should I do for a weekend in Squamish?" "Easy hikes for beginners near Whistler?"

Useful Links

Resource	Link
BC Parks day passes	bcparks.ca
DriveBC road conditions	drivebc.ca
Whistler Blackcomb snow report	whistlerblackcomb.com
Weather (Squamish)	weather.gc.ca

Best Sea to Sky

850+ listings across Squamish, Whistler & Pemberton

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